

THE GOOEY STUFF

The story of GUI, the innovation that kickstarted it all

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If you're a denizen of the electronic world and use anything that has some sense of smartness about it, you've used a Graphical User Interface (GUI). In a highly touch driven world, the GUI is not only omnipresent, it is essential in determining the fate of a particular innovation. As long as tech is made for humans, GUIs will be an imperative part of any technology.

While some of you may already know about Steve Job's now historic visit to the Xerox PARC center where he saw a GUI in operation for the first time ever, most tech users are clueless about the origins of something that they use on a daily basis. What is even more unknown is that the quest for a compact, user-friendly personal computing interface began long before that.

BEFORE IT COULD BE DONE

The initial idea, or at best a concept, behind the graphical user interface came long before the technology to make it happen was even remotely ready. Vannevar Bush postulated a device called the Memex in the 1930s.

The concept looked like a desk with two touch screen graphical displays, a keyboard, and a scanner attached to it. Obviously, none of this could be actually made back then, as there was little to no interest in digital computers. Bush's work went largely unnoticed until World War II was around the corner, when a rush to stay ahead on the technology front had gripped almost every nation around the world. Unknown to Bush, his speculations would actually inspire a generation of innovators to work towards making the GUI a reality around this time.

Douglas Engelbart was one such innovator, who decided to quit his comfortable job at the NACA Institute (what would later become NASA) and build something not too different from Bush's vision. Of course, his years of experience during the war as a radar

operator would prove to be crucial in his understanding of a cathode-ray tube display based UI controllable by the user. In a time when entering text in real time into a computer was considered a radical idea, Engelbart and his team worked for years to bring

about something that would change the world of GUI as we know it. It was 1968 when it all changed.



Douglas Engelbart, the man
behind the mouse

AND ONE MORE THING...

Douglas Engelbart's historic demonstration was overwhelming to say the least. The system was called NLS, or oN-Line System. The display of the system was vector-based and

was capable of displaying both text and solid lines on the same screen. The system also featured what would be the precursor of the modern mouse, in the form of a three-button device that let the user perform actions not too